

Beautiful Dashboards, **Zero Adoption.**

Lessons from the real world



Big thank you to our great sponsors



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*Interested in the gap between
good reports and real adoption*



**“ Looks great...
can you just send me
the Excel?”**

Who has heard this? Who has said it?

A SHORT INTRODUCTION

I have been wrong about users for 20 years

25

years working with BI

10

years with Power BI

1

small country
and many real-world lessons

Independent consultant · Finance, operations and management reporting

WHY THIS TOPIC

Technically correct

Visually polished

Unused in the decision



The adoption problem often begins after the dashboard is finished.

THE EASY STORY

My original explanation was convenient

**“Users resist change.
They love Excel.
They do not understand visual reporting.”**

Often true in small pieces. Often wrong as the full explanation.

A BETTER EXPLANATION

They are protecting four things

TRUST

Is this the
official
number?

VALIDATION

Can I prove
where it came
from?

HABIT

Does it fit
the real
workflow?

ACCOUNTABILITY

Can I explain it
when challenged?

People are not always resisting Power BI.
Sometimes they are protecting a process they trust.

BEFORE I BUILT THIS SESSION

I had assumptions.
So I asked.

After years of building BI solutions, I had my own ideas about why adoption fails.

THE RULE

Don't assume. Ask.

Because “Can I get the Excel?” can mean something very different from what we think.

WE ASSUME

- They just want Excel
- They don't understand visuals
- They are resisting change
- They don't trust the report

MAYBE THEY NEED TO

- Validate the numbers
- Explain the result
- Follow an existing process
- Protect accountability

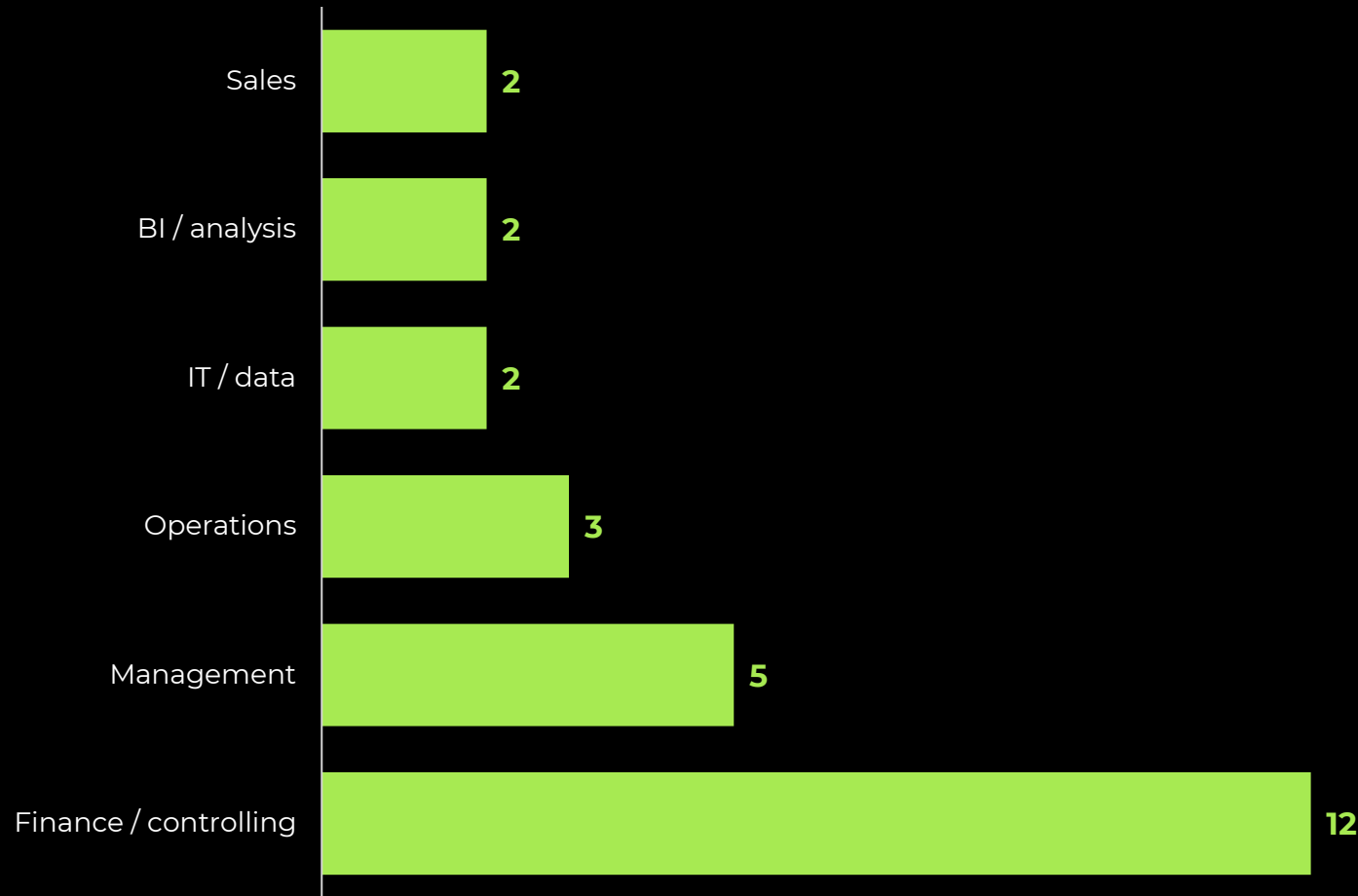
But assumptions are dangerous.
So I asked real report users.

What users really mean by trust

Evidence from 26 active BI users

26 ANONYMOUS RESPONSES

The sample is small. But close to the decision



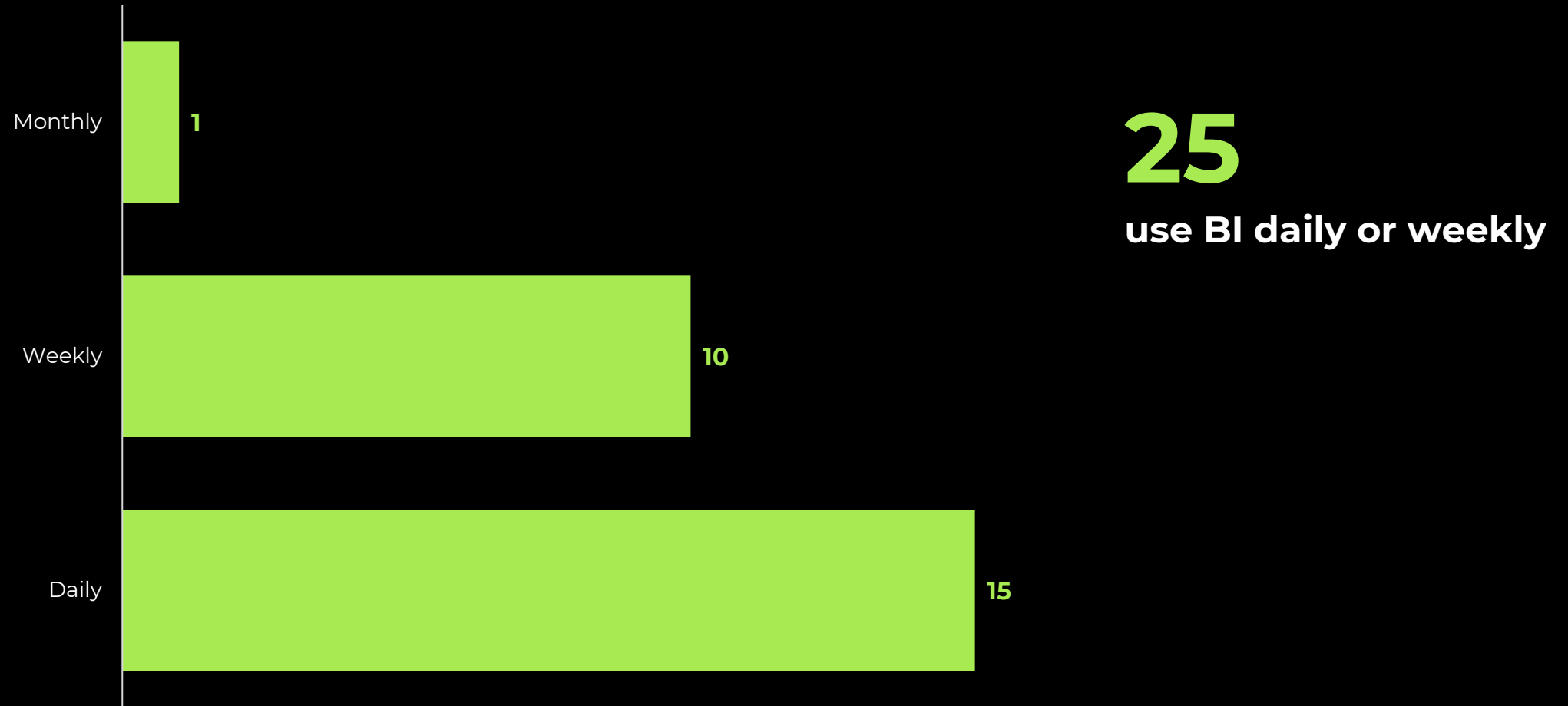
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**work in finance or
management**

These are people who have
to use, explain and defend
numbers.

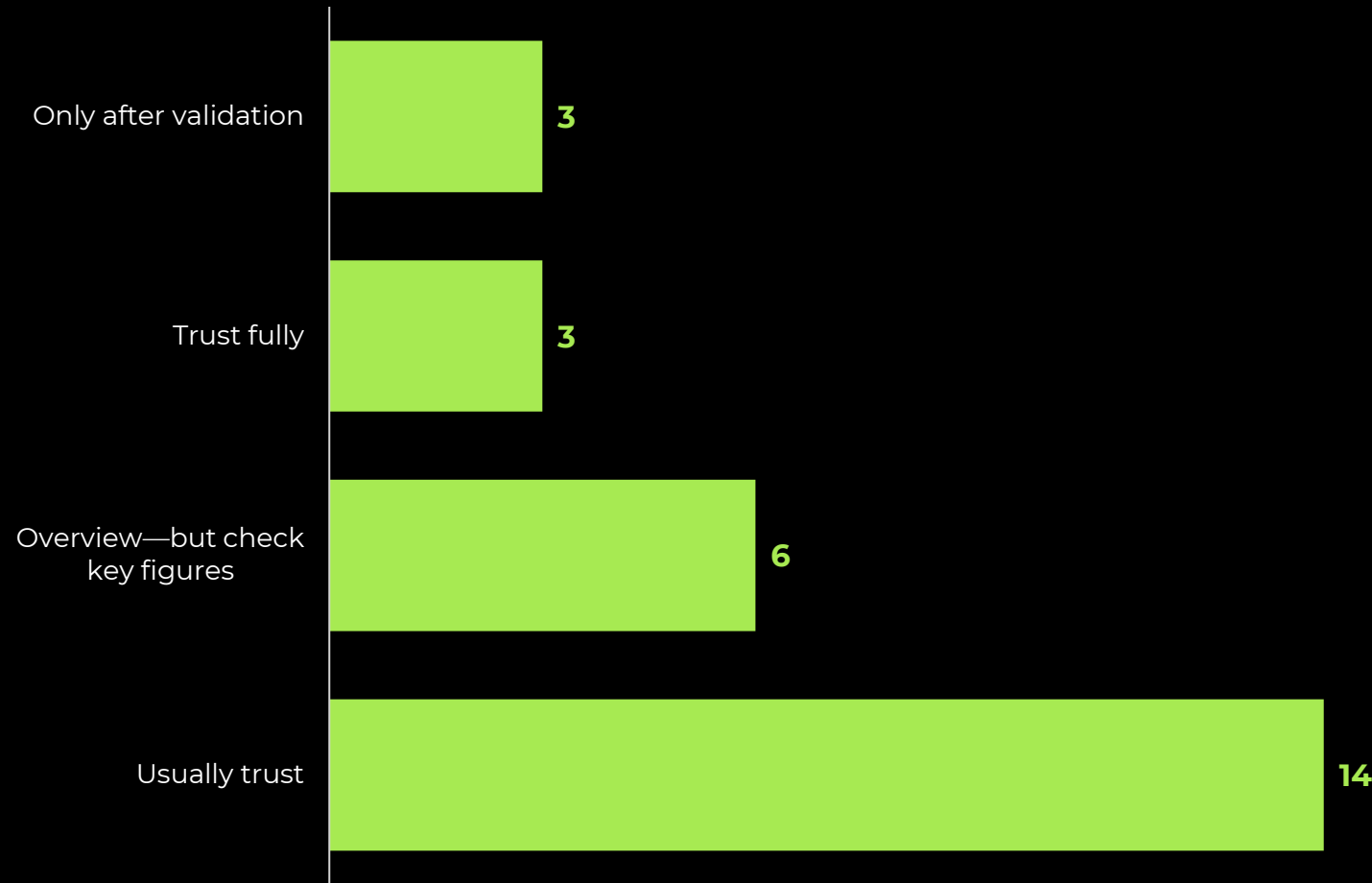
HOW OFTEN THEY USE BI

These are active users *not BI outsiders*



HOW MUCH THEY TRUST THE NUMBERS

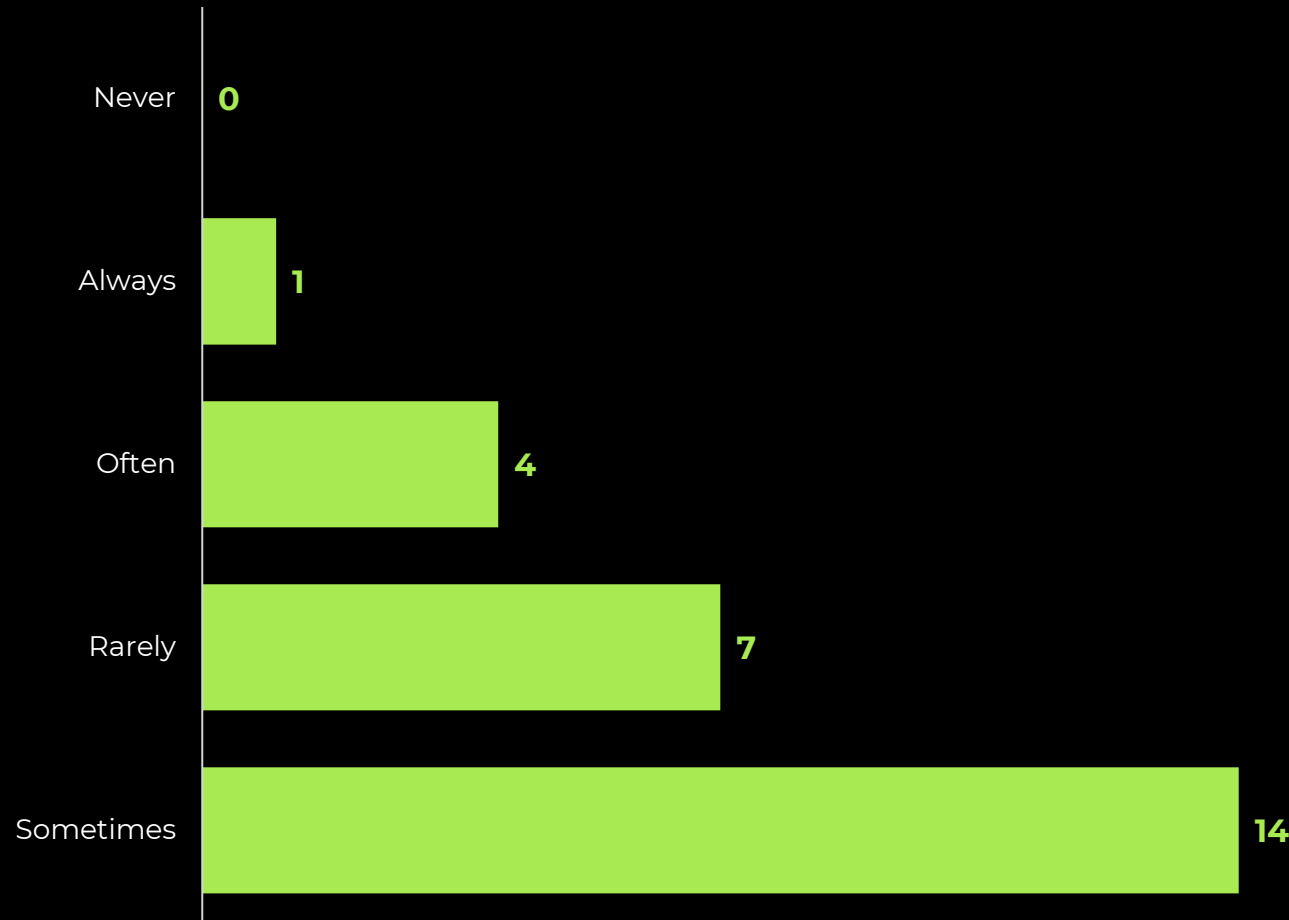
Most users trust BI *with conditions*



**Trust is not binary.
It changes with the
number, the decision
and the consequence.**

HOW OFTEN THEY VALIDATE

Every respondent still checks the numbers

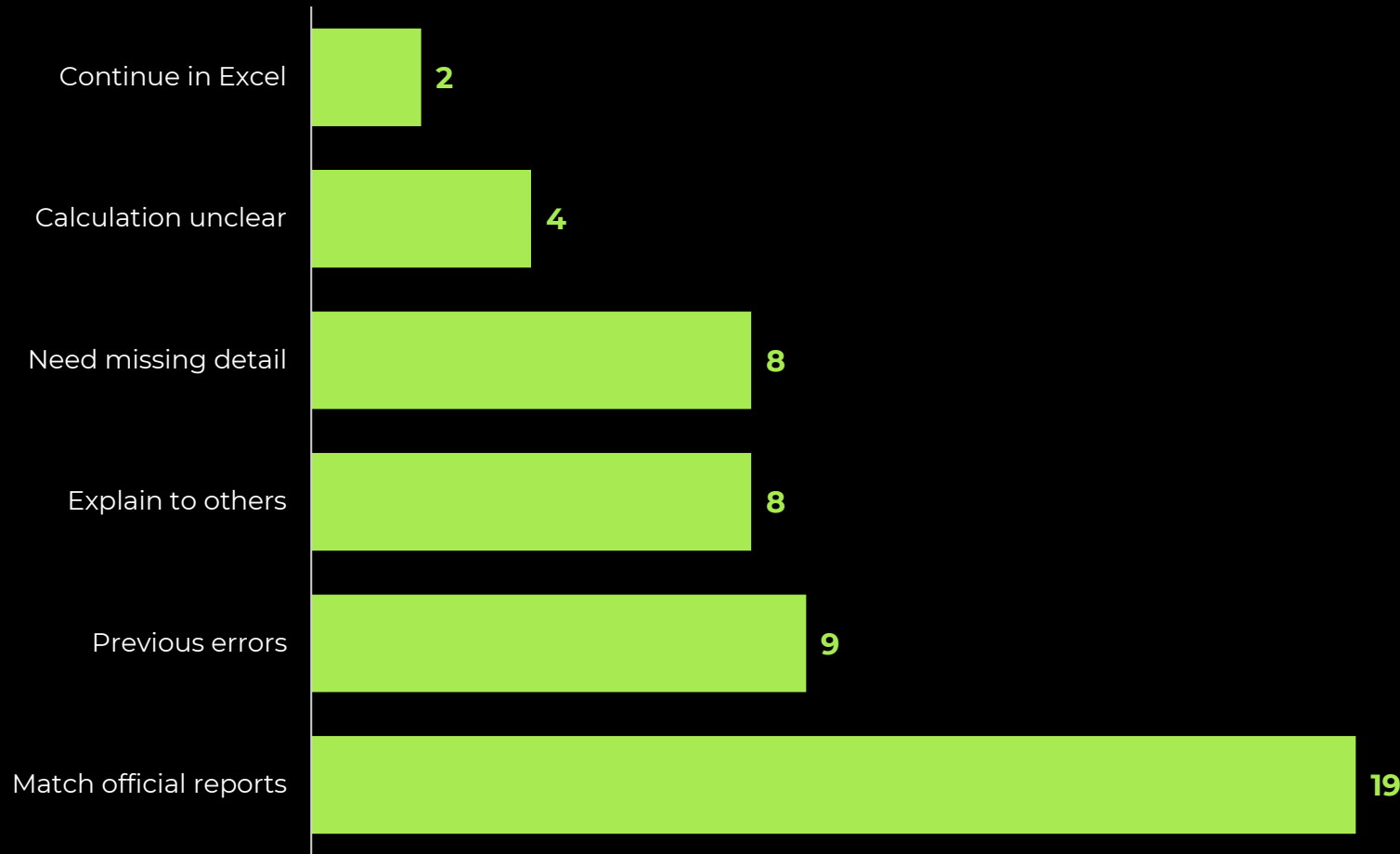


0

said they never validate

WHY THEY CHECK

They validate because the number must survive scrutiny



**19 of 26
reconcile with
official reports
or accounts.**

**That is accountability
not nostalgia.**

THE SURVEY IN ONE SENTENCE

Users trust BI
but when the number matters,
they still need to verify it.

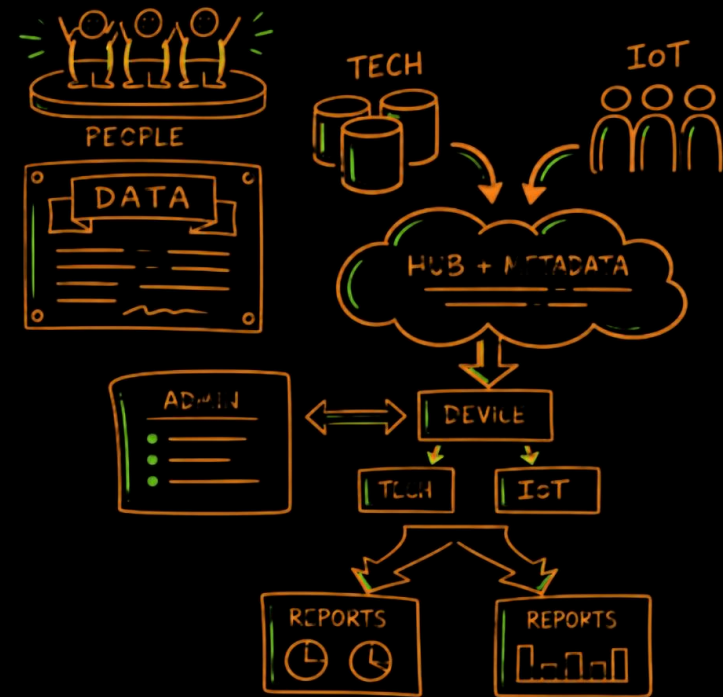
Validation is not a sign of failure. It is part of how business works.

Design for validation

A report should lead users from attention to evidence

KEEP IT SIMPEL

TALK.
SKETCH.
CHANGE.
OWN.



When people help design it, they are more likely to make it their own.

THREE LAYERS

Design the path from overview to proof

OVERVIEW

EXPLAIN

VALIDATE



See what changed



Understand why



Prove the number

A TRUST PAGE

Reconciliation turns doubt into a controlled difference

KNOWN REPORT

12,450,000

BI REPORT

12,425,000

EXPLAINED DIFFERENCE

–

=

25,000

Timing difference

Mapping difference

Known scope exclusion

MAKE THE CALCULATION AUDITABLE

A measure needs a human explanation

GROSS MARGIN %

**(Revenue – Cost of Sales)
÷ Revenue**

PLAIN LANGUAGE

What is included?

What is excluded?

Which date and currency?

Who owns the definition?

A DAX formula can be correct and still fail as communication.

A FALSE CHOICE

Tables are not the enemy

VISUALS

Reveal patterns

Show movement

Direct attention

TABLES

Give exact values

Show hierarchy

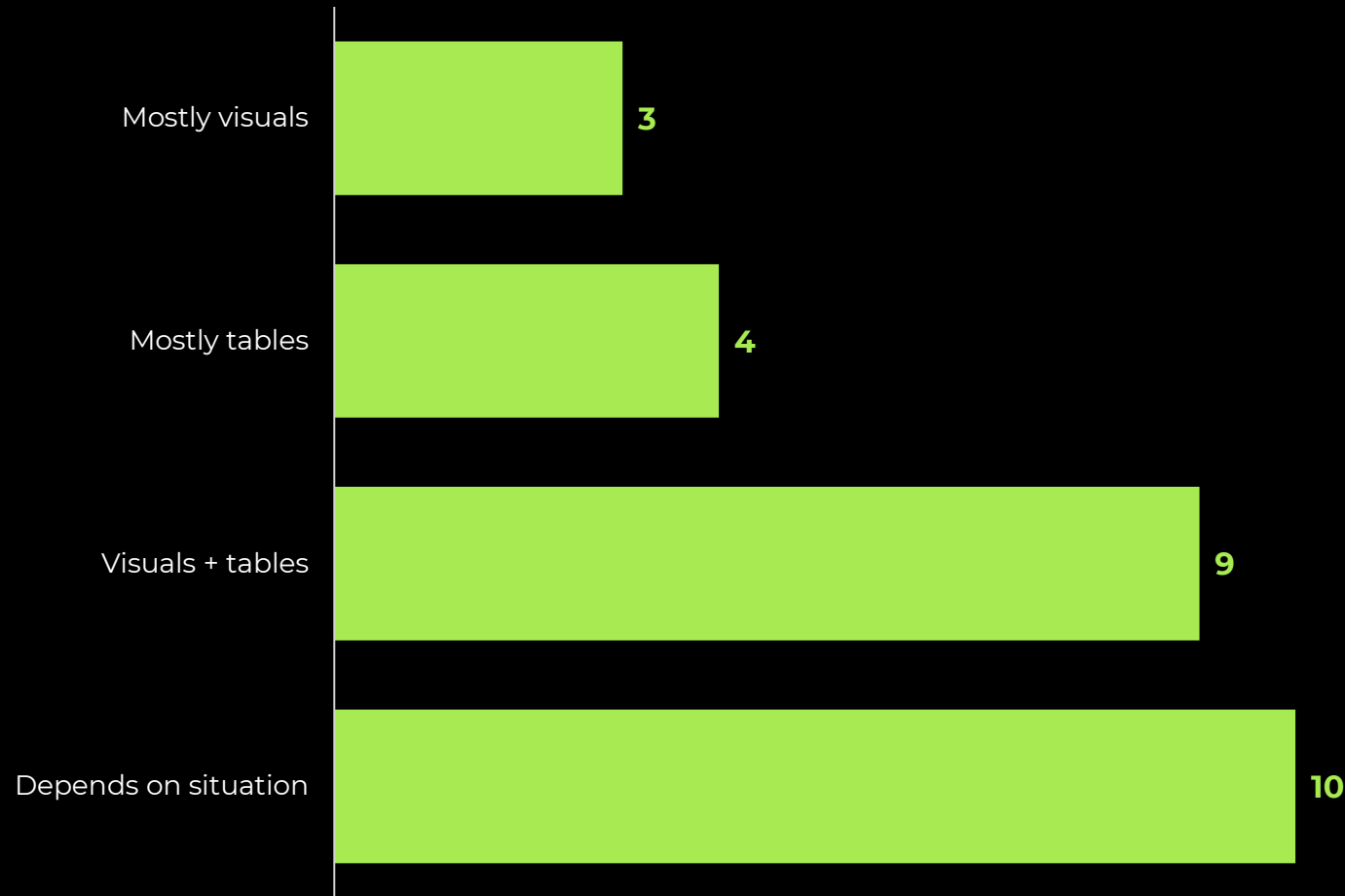
Support checking

Visuals help people see what is happening.

Tables help them believe and explain it.

PREFERRED REPORT FORMAT

Only 3 of 26 prefer mostly visuals



**The right format
depends on the
question—not the
designer's preference.**

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Simple is what the user sees
after we have handled the
complexity—
not before.

Calm default. Progressive depth. Complete audit trail.

BAD SIMPLICITY / BAD COMPLEXITY

Complexity becomes visible when everything competes

12 KPIs

7 colours

5 slicers

3 tables

4 Chart type

Tiny help text

**No clean
question**

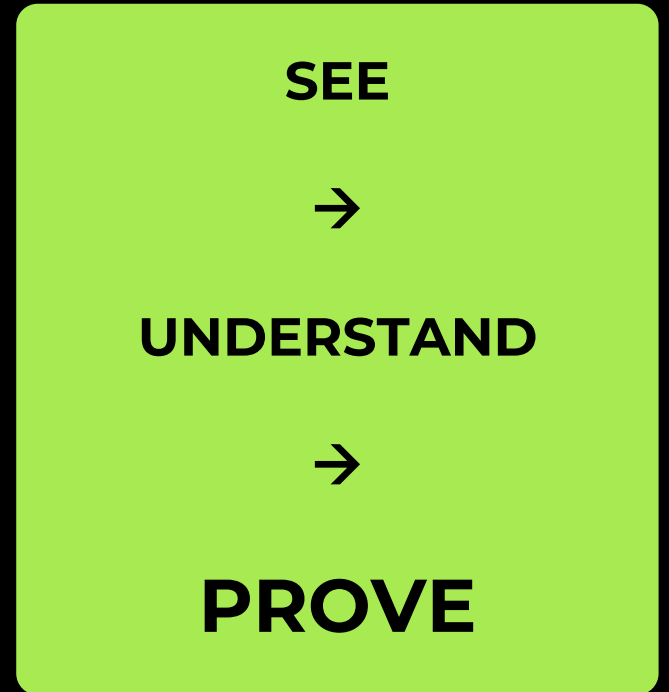
**No path to
detail**

More information on one page can produce less understanding.

A PRACTICAL CHECKLIST

Good simplicity keeps the depth one click away

- ❑ Show refresh time and active scope
- ❑ Name the source system or owner
- ❑ Define calculations where ambiguity is likely
- ❑ Reconcile key totals with trusted outputs
- ❑ Make the supporting detail easy to reach
- ❑ Keep the default view calm

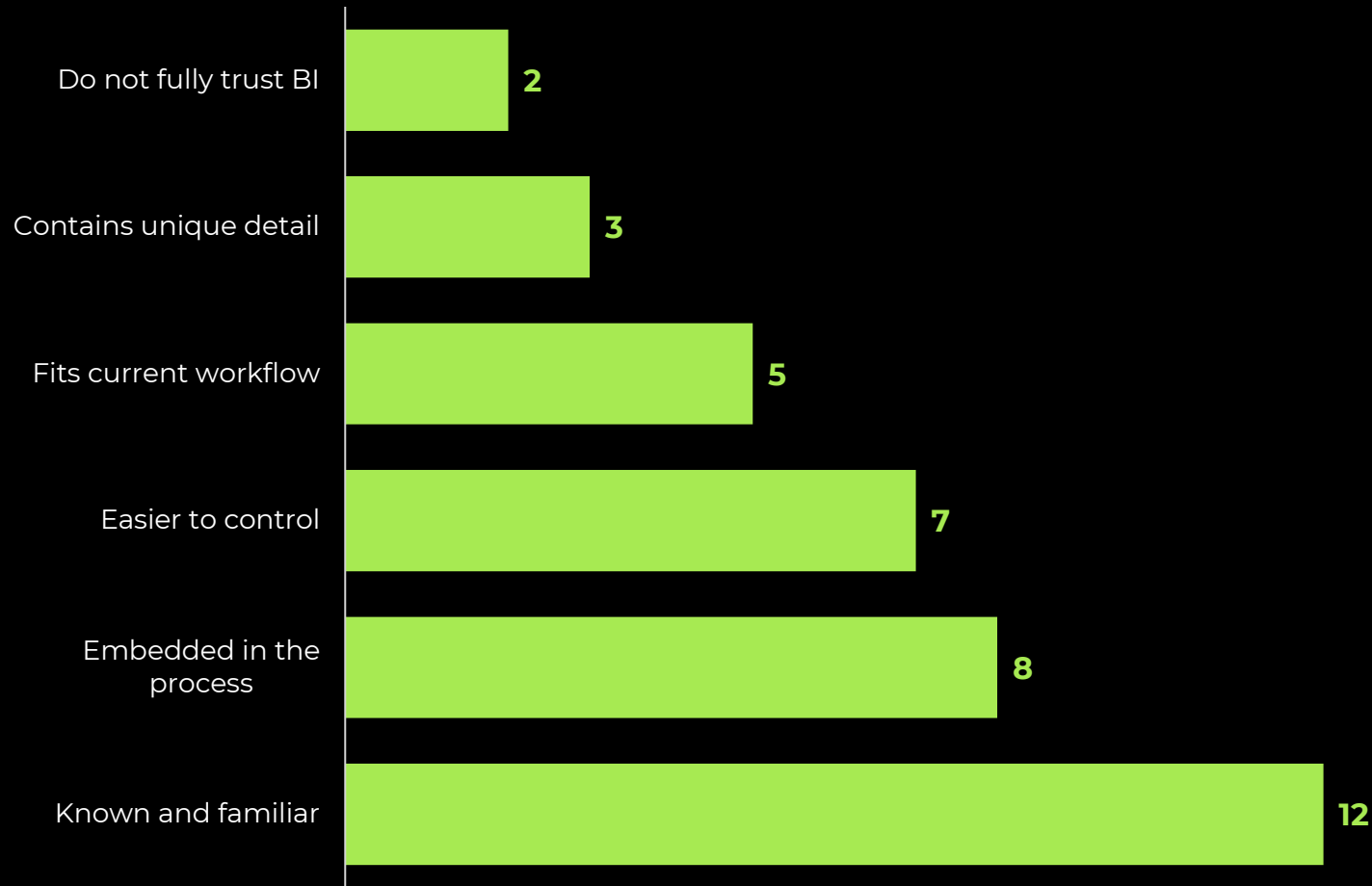


Change habits without breaking trust

Adoption is a transition, not a launch date

WHY PEOPLE KEEP USING THEM

Old reports survive because they still do a job



**Familiarity is not
irrational.
It is accumulated
operational confidence.**

A SAFER ROLLOUT

Adoption grows through successful repetition

ANCHOR

COMPARE

EXPLAIN

TRANSFER

Known definitions
and totals

Old and new
in parallel

Resolve differences
openly

Complete the real
task in BI

A redesign changes the screen. Adoption changes the working process.

“**It takes time and courage.**

— Anonymous survey response

Trust grows when the report works
repeatedly in the moments that matter.

THE FINAL FRAMEWORK

The adoption test has three questions

SEE

UNDERSTAND

PROVE

Can I see what changed?

Can I understand why?

Can I prove the number?

- Do not fight validation; design for it
- Use visuals to see and tables to prove
- Change habits gradually; trust grows through successful repetition

What can users prove in Excel that they cannot yet prove here?

FIVE PRACTICAL MOVES

What to change tomorrow

1. Show refresh time and active scope
2. Explain one important calculation
3. Reconcile one KPI with a trusted total
4. Add a clear path to supporting detail
5. Watch how users validate; not only where they click

THREE THINGS TO REMEMBER

1

Do not fight
validation.
Design for it.

2

Use visuals to see
and tables to
prove.

3

Change habits
gradually.
Trust grows
through repetition.

BACK TO THE OPENING QUESTION

“Looks great... can you just send me the Excel?”

What can users prove in Excel that they cannot yet prove here?

Thank you.

A dashboard is adopted when it helps people move from question to proof without leaving the report.

“We have been lying in the Excel sheets for 30 years, so it is hard to get rid of the smell.”
— Anonymous survey response

Raffle prizes from the sponsors



Session feedback

